

Hack the Museum: LBJ Presidential Library

SP26 Themed Entertainment Design

THE POWER OF SMALL THINGS



Interactive Museum Tour Designed By
Chelsea Lee & Rihanna Lyu

CONCEPT OVERVIEW



Why LBJ?

Lyndon B. Johnson is considered one of the most influential leaders in U.S. presidential history. While the museum highlights his political achievements and policies, we wanted to focus on a more personal aspect of his leadership that most people didn't know about, coming from his warm and familiar personality.

During our first visit, we were especially inspired by the museum senior docents who had lived through LBJ's presidency. Their stories added a personal layer to history; it came to like real life experiences beyond historical facts. Hearing these perspectives made us realize that what stood out most was not just LBJ's political power, but his ability to build genuine, lasting relationships.

His habit of gifting everyday items like electrical toothbrushes and razors showed a deeper leadership strategies that influence is not always made by grand actions, but through small, genuine actions that create personal connection.

What is the experience?

This experience transforms LBJ's leadership style into interactive activity that is based on role-playing game. Visitors engage with the idea that everyday objects can carry meaning and be used as tools of diplomacy and politics.

Visitors play as world leaders persuading others through gifting strategies by using everyday object. Rather than observing history as passive guests, they become active participants of the tour engaging in psychological side of diplomacy learning how subtle actions can hold significant political and emotional weight.

The experience highlights decision-making, storytelling, and persuasion as tools of leadership.

Historical museum can be boring; but this tour will shift your perspective — from something feels hard and rigid to something personal and familiar.

GAMES

Introducing our special interactive activities



GAME PLAY

1. Draw Cards

Draw 3 Object Cards & 2 Strategy Cards from the deck.

1 Object Card
+ 1 Psychological
Influence Card
+ 1 Strategic Value Card

2. Plan Your Move

Select 1 object + 2 strategy cards to combine.

Think about how they work together to persuade others.

3. Present Your Argument

Explain how your strategy works with your chosen gift.

Convince others by explaining your object through storytelling with your intention and context.

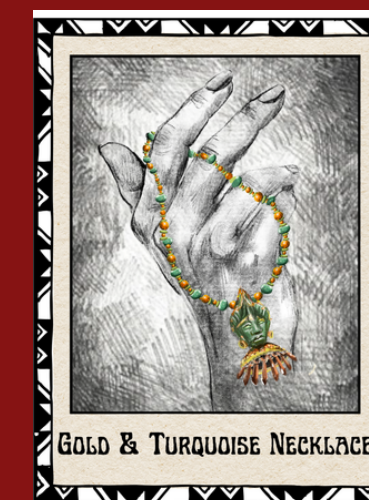
4. Vote

Other teams/players decide the most persuasive strategy.

The team with the strongest argument becomes the winner.

OBJECT CARDS

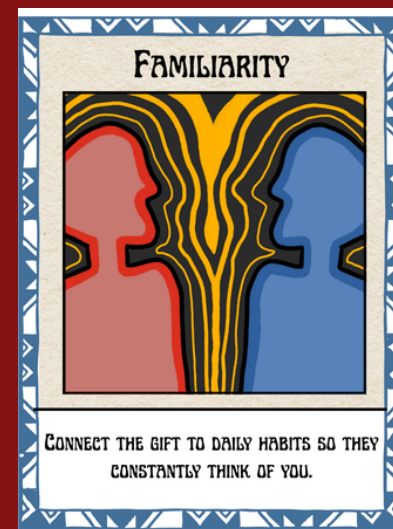
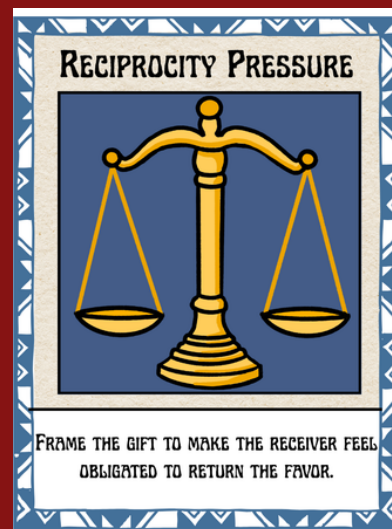
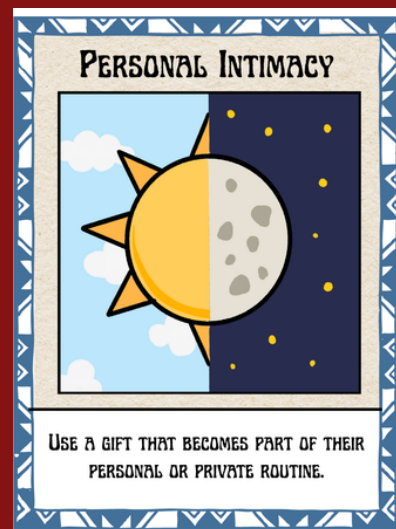
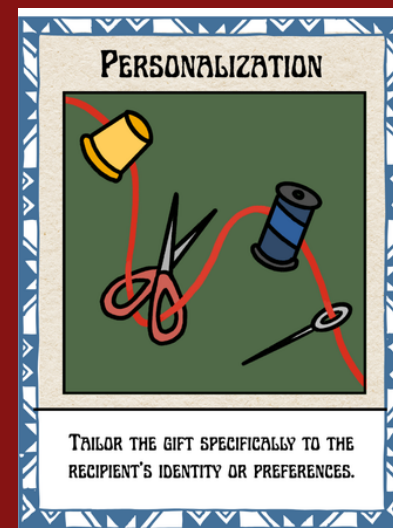
: Gifts given to Lyndon B. Johnson and Lady Bird Johnson during their presidency



STRATEGY CARDS

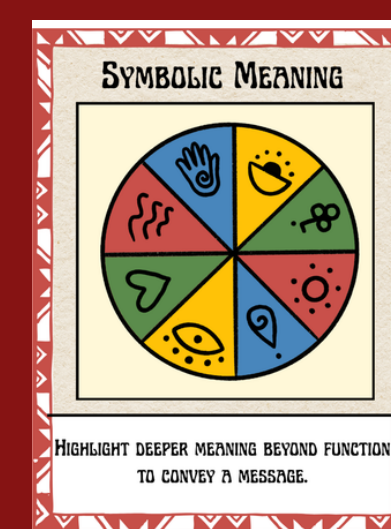
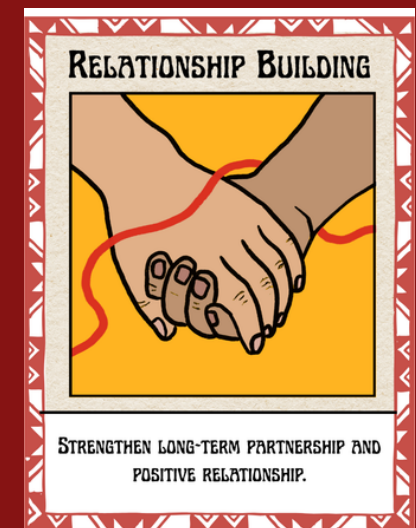
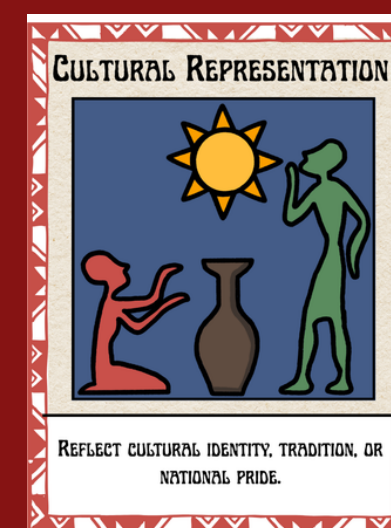
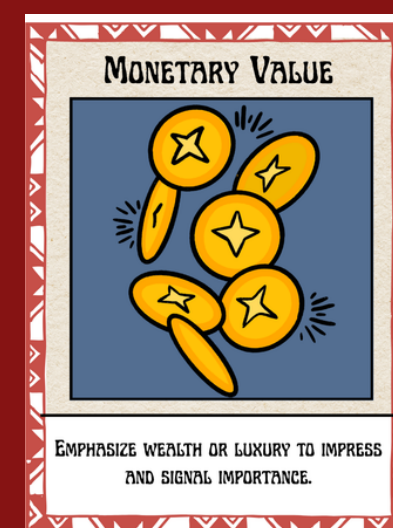
PSYCHOLOGICAL INFLUENCE

: Emotional value of the item



STRATEGIC VALUE

: Purpose of gift & its significance



GUIDES

Power is not always about something “big” — sometimes, it’s coming from something personal.



TOUR BROCHURE

BEFORE YOUR TOUR

Your tour is an interactive experience that transforms political and psychological strategies into a role-playing board game inspired by Lyndon Baines Johnson's approachable leadership style and his use of meaningful gestures to build lasting relationships. Your goal is to use a gift and pair it with an influence strategy to persuade other teams and earn the most points. Every team is playing as a world leader using uses objects as tools of diplomacy.

GAME PLAY

01. DRAW CARDS

Draw 3 object cards and 2 strategy cards from the deck.

02. PLAN YOUR MOVE

Think how you can pair them up together and select 1 object + 1 strategy card from your cards.

03. PRESENT YOUR ARGUMENT

Explain how your strategy works with your chosen gift and persuade others.

04. VOTE

Other teams/players decide the most persuasive strategy.

STRATEGY SYSTEM

Psychological Influence

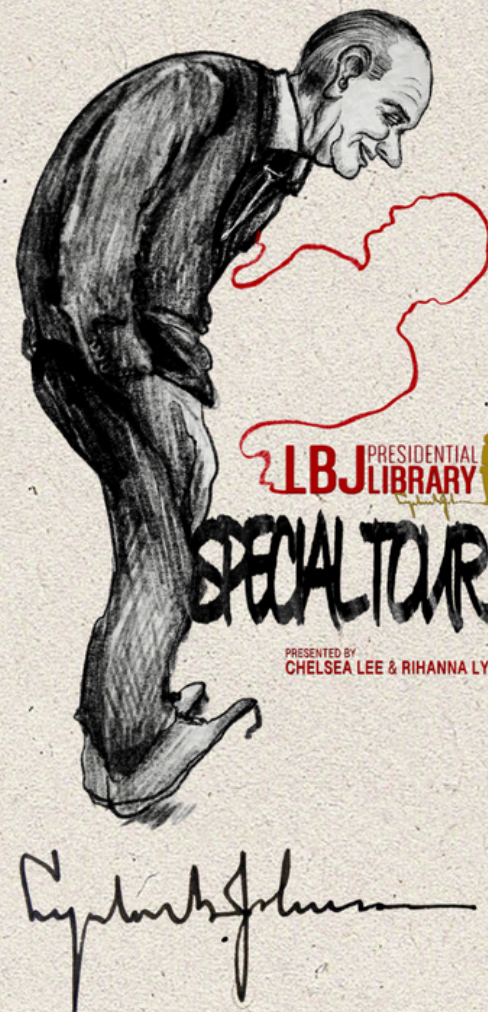
How this gift makes people feel?

- Emotional Attachment
- Personal Intimacy
- Familiarity
- Reciprocity
- Personalization
- Public Image

Strategic Value

What does the gift do?
& Why does it matter?

- Cultural Representation
- Monetary Value
- Necessity
- Symbolic Meaning
- Show of Power
- Relationship Building



“

President Johnson loved to shower people with gifts... his favorites were electric razors and toothbrushes because he wanted people to remember him the first thing in the morning and the last thing at night...



ABOUT OBJECTS



Gold and Turquoise Necklace

This carved turquoise pendant hanging from silver chain was a gift to Lynda Bird Johnson from Mexican President Gustavo Diaz Ordaz in 1964.

Saudi Ceremonial Sword

This sword with a mounted emerald and gold sheath was a gift from King Faisal from Saudi Arabia in 1966.



Demitasse Cup and Saucer Set

It was a gift that represents each country from foreign journalists to Lady Bird Johnson after she led a "Visit USA" Tour in 1968.

Malachite Box

Gift to LBJ from Alexsei N. Kosygin, chairman of the council of Ministers of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics at the meeting in Glassboro, New Jersey in 1967.



Candlestick

Ludwig Erhard, German Chancellor, gave this to President and Mrs. Johnson during his visit to the Ranch in December 1963.

Purse

Lady Bird Johnson received this gold purse with Asian traditional pattern on it during her Trip to Asia in 1966.



Slippers

Designed by Mollie Parnis, a famous American fashion designer First Ladies, these slippers feature the Great Seal of the United States sewed on the top.

LBJ Bobblehead

Our funny take! This is a popular collectible figurines. Don't you want LBJ's political souvenirs?



The exchange of gifts has held us together. It has made it possible to bridge the abyss, where language struggles.

- Barry Lopez

RESEARCH

Our research focused on political relationship strategies, gift diplomacy, and how gift exchange functions as a tool for building relationships. We also explored role-playing game techniques and the psychological facts behind gifting. Research sources are historical articles, museum and government archives, academic research papers, and online publications.

Link to Planning & Research Docs:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/13LkqMnRBC9IhcUhNdgmxrNzghb56Yt8G6dPCFBLXr_Y/edit?usp=sharing

SCRIPT

The following script is designed for tour guides to give more details to visitors. Initial plan for whole tour is 20 minutes with 5-7 minutes of game play and 15 minutes of estimated reading time.

Link to Script Docs:

<https://docs.google.com/document/d/1RPCuEyzg9Na17zDDxqJBYKL5CKCEg6ocfkNbS7amQM/edit?usp=sharing>



“The smallest gestures can carry the greatest influence”

GOSSTIP



LBJ'S INTIMATE POLITICS: POWER THROUGH PERSONAL GESTURE

Stories behind toothbrush & razor

Beyond policy and power, Lyndon B. Johnson was known for his personal way of building relationships. One of the most interesting examples is his habit of gifting simple, daily items like toothbrushes and razors.

He wanted people to remember him every morning and every night, becoming a part of person's daily routine.

This story stood out to us during our visit, shifting our perception of small gestures as simple actions into meaningful tools that can build strong relationships and influence diplomacy.

“

President Johnson loved to shower people with gifts... his favorites were electric razors and toothbrushes because he wanted people to remember him the first thing in the morning and the last thing at night...



SMALL GESTURES MATTER

Gift-giving is not just an exchange of objects
→ it is psychological actions that can build strong relationships

Small, familiar items create:

- Emotional attachment: to daily routines
- Repetition & memory: seen and used consistently increasing familiarity
- Personal connection: feels more “intimate” than formal and traditional

Research on gift diplomacy shows that gifts can be used as tools to:

- Build trust and mutual respect
- Signal intention and alignment
- Strengthen long-term relationships
- Cultural representation (essence of nation)
- Symbol of democracy



RECAP

Games

- Interactive role-playing strategy game activity based on storytelling
- Card system (object + strategy) visually helping participants understand how gift-diplomacy strategies work

Guides

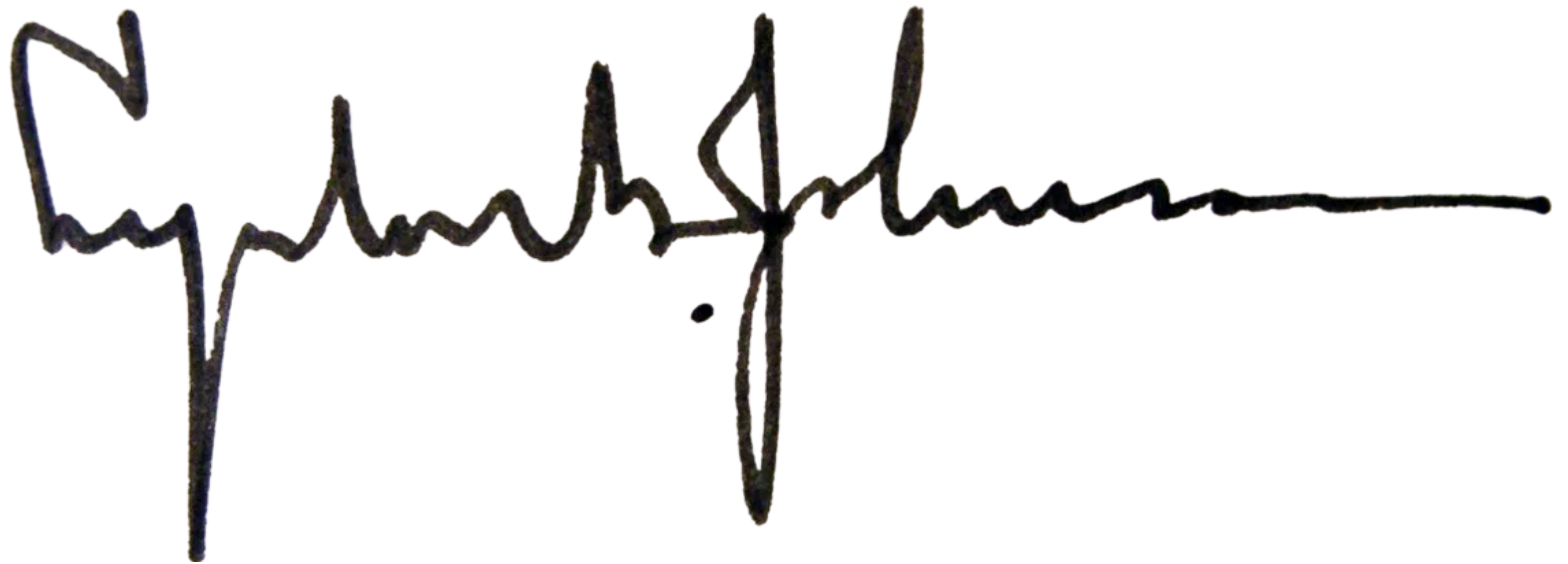
- Handout brochure & cards contain information in a visually engaging and accessible format
- Script explaining & introducing overview of LBJ's historical background

Gossip

- Lesser-known fun facts behind electric toothbrush & razor
- Research on gift diplomacy about political and psychological strategies connecting with LBJ's gifting habit of use of everyday objects



THANK YOU

A handwritten signature in dark ink, likely of Lyndon B. Johnson, featuring a large initial 'L' and a long, sweeping horizontal stroke at the end.

CREDITS

This presentation template was created by Canva, including image from National Archives (<https://www.archives.gov/>) and LBJ Presidential Library (<https://www.lbjlibrary.org/>)

Visuals in game & brochure are designed by Chelsea Lee and Rihanna Lyu